(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Bronchitis

Bronchitis is inflammation of the airways in the lungs that is usually caused by an infection. It often gets better without treatment in around 3 weeks.

Some people have long-term inflammation of the airways in the lungs called chronic bronchitis. This is known as chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/chronic-obstructive-pulmonary-disease-copd/).

Symptoms of bronchitis

The symptoms of bronchitis can be similar to a cold or flu.

Symptoms include:

- a cough – you may cough up mucus
- chest pain when coughing
- shortness of breath
- a sore throat
- a runny nose
- a high temperature

Things you can do to help with bronchitis

Bronchitis is often caused by infections that can be easily spread through coughing and sneezing.

There are some things you can do to ease the symptoms of bronchitis and reduce the risk of spreading infections to other people.

Do

- ✓ get plenty of rest – try to stay at home and avoid contact with other people if you have a high temperature or do not feel well enough to do your normal activities
- ✓ drink plenty of fluids
- ✓ take painkillers like paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) or ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/) to help with pain and bring down a high temperature
- ✓ try adding honey to a warm drink to help soothe your throat (do not give honey to babies under 1)
- ✓ cover your mouth and nose with a tissue when you cough or sneeze – put used tissues in the bin as quickly as possible
- ✓ wash your hands regularly with water and soap

Don’t

- ✗ do not smoke

When and where to get medical help

Bronchitis usually gets better on its own, but you may need medical advice if your symptoms do not get any better.

You should also get advice if you have a health issue that makes you more vulnerable to bronchitis, like having diabetes.

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

- you've had a cough for more than 3 weeks and it is not getting better
- you cough up blood or blood-stained mucus
- you have chest pain that comes and goes, or when breathing or coughing
- you're over 65
- you're pregnant
- you have a long-term condition, such as diabetes, or a heart, lung or kidney condition
- you have a weakened immune system – for example, you have a condition that affects the immune system, or you're having chemotherapy
- you feel too unwell to do usual daily activities
- you're feeling short of breath

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms). Call 111 if you need advice for a child aged 4 years or under.

Call 999 if:

- you are struggling to breathe – you are choking, gasping and unable to speak
- your lips or skin are turning very pale, blue or grey – on brown or black skin this may be easier to see on the palms of the hands, on the lips, tongue or gums, under the nails or around the eyes
- you suddenly feel confused – for example, you do not know where you are
- you're unable to wake your baby or they feel floppy

Do not drive yourself to A&E.

The person you speak to at 999 will give you advice about what to do.

Treatments for bronchitis

Bronchitis usually clears up without treatment in around 3 weeks. See a GP if your symptoms last longer than 3 weeks.

Antibiotics may be offered if your bronchitis is caused by a more serious infection.

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